

Obstacles to Trump-Kim summit likely insurmountable in near term

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【メール原文】

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North Korea

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South Korea was alarmed at President Donald Trump's unilateral decision to reduce joint training exercises last month, but Seoul will support Washington's renewed outreach to North Korea and a push to reduce tensions on the Korean Peninsula.

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Nevertheless, a summit between Trump and North Korean leader Kim Jong-un remains unlikely to come together by November despite a recent softening of positions that has prompted speculation a meeting could take place when Trump next travels to Asia.

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Kim is in a significantly stronger geopolitical position than during Trump's first term, and he will likely demand a cancellation of US-South Korea joint military exercises or recognition of North Korea's nuclear program before returning to the negotiating table—concessions that Trump is unlikely to offer.

South Korea will support a resumption of US-North Korea talks. Seoul was blindsided by Trump's reduction of joint military exercises last month, which was not coordinated with South Korea. But President Lee Jae-myung has pushed Trump to resume talks with Pyongyang since he took office last year and will likely repeat this message when he visits the US later this month. Kim has no interest in negotiating directly with Lee, despite the South Korean leader's efforts to reduce tensions with North Korea, leaving Trump as the only potential interlocutor for Seoul.

Nevertheless, Trump and Kim are unlikely to meet in November despite a recent softening in positions. There is little indication of real movement toward planning a summit with Kim when Trump next travels to Asia. Despite Trump's public courting of Kim via social media, Pyongyang continues to rebuff Trump's outreach while leaving the door open for dialogue down the line. Kim can afford to take his time, needing Washington less than he did during the last round of talks with Trump that collapsed in 2019. Meanwhile, Trump is viewed by Pyongyang to be in a weaker negotiating position and more desperate for a foreign policy win.

North Korea remains unfinished business for Trump. He continues to express interest in resuming diplomacy with Kim without preconditions and speaks about Kim in friendly terms. Trump attempted to schedule a last-minute rendezvous with Kim at the demilitarized zone between North Korea and South Korea when he last visited Asia in October 2025 (Kim ignored that invitation), and he is likely hoping to

arrange a meeting with Kim when he returns to Asia in November for the APEC summit. Trump's sudden decision to reduce joint US-South Korea military exercises last month was a low-cost effort to kickstart talks with Kim. He will, however, be reluctant to offer much more, including overturning decades of US policy toward North Korea's nuclear weapons program.

Kim is open to resuming dialogue with Trump—for the right price. The North Korean leader has avoided criticizing Trump since his reelection and signaled that he would be willing to meet again. Kim would likely demand the US cancel military exercises with South Korea or remove denuclearization from the agenda as a precondition for reentering talks. Pyongyang's requests are deliberately ambiguous though, which could allow Kim to accept a tacit arrangement whereby the two leaders defer discussion of denuclearization while disagreeing over the significance of it. Such an approach would allow Trump and Kim to focus on more achievable outcomes. Those outcomes could include a potential freeze on North Korea's long-range missile tests or a reduction of its military support for Russia in return for sanctions relief, a formal peace treaty ending the Korean War, or a reduction in US security assistance to South Korea.

North Korea is in a significantly stronger geopolitical position today than it was during Trump's first term. Since the leaders last met, Pyongyang has formed a quasi-security alliance with Russia and repaired ties with China. Both Moscow and Beijing nominally supported UN sanctions against North Korea's weapons program during Trump's first term, but they have since dropped their denuclearization demands and now oppose UN efforts to pressure North Korea's regime. In the last three years, Kim has made rare visits to both countries and hosted their leaders on reciprocal visits to North Korea, highlighting the increased importance that both Moscow and Beijing place on their relations with Pyongyang.

North Korea's weapons program has also made significant strides since Trump's first term, aided by weakening sanctions enforcement and Russian technological assistance. In 2018, North Korea was estimated to have at most 10-20 nuclear warheads; today, it likely has 80 to 120 warheads, according to South Korean intelligence. Its missile technology has also improved, incorporating solid-fuel technology and longer ranges that make them stealthier and put the continental US within range. While the frequency of North Korea's ballistic missile tests has fallen since 2022, and the regime has not carried out a nuclear test since 2017, the threat posed by its weapons program continues to grow.

China and Japan will seek to protect their interests. Beijing is positioning itself to play a potential mediating role—President Xi Jinping has visited both Koreas in the last year—and could host Trump-Kim talks if they come together by November's APEC summit. China would, however, oppose a US-North Korea rapprochement that reduced Beijing's influence with Pyongyang. Tokyo would similarly worry that a Trump-Kim deal could come at the expense of Japan's interests, particularly on the politically sensitive issue of Japanese abductees held in North Korea.

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